INTRODUCTION

A Brazen Lie?

The 2012 U.S. presidential race ended according to the forecast, with a decisive victory for Barack Obama. But the closing days did bring one unusual development: the most emphatic collective debunking of a major campaign claim in the modern history of American journalism. The episode presaged what would be ubiquitous political fact-checking in the primaries four years later, when reporters' instincts were sharpened by unusually wild rhetoric from several political outsiders—in particular a famous real estate mogul and reality TV star. In hindsight, it was all the more remarkable for centering on a comparatively mild campaign claim from the consummate establishment candidate.

At the tail end of October, with Election Day less than two weeks away, the campaign of Republican contender Mitt Romney began airing a tough new ad in the crucial swing state of Ohio. Polls showed President Obama performing unusually well among white working-class voters there, bolstered by the evident success of the government's 2009 bailout of U.S. automakers. In his own commercials, Obama mercilessly exploited his opponent's very public opposition to the bailout, which had included a *New York Times* op-ed with the unfortunate title "Let Detroit Go Bankrupt."[1] Romney's new attack ad, called "Who Will Do More?," seized on a news bulletin out of Detroit to

cast the government's role in a different light. Over images of old sedans being flattened by an industrial press, a male voice offered a harsh appraisal of the White House's record: "Obama took GM and Chrysler into bankruptcy and sold Chrysler to the Italians, who are going to build Jeeps in China." As evidence for the last point, the ad flashed an out-of-context excerpt from a recent financial news item reporting that Chrysler "plans to return Jeep output to China."

The attack finessed a charge Romney had made more bluntly two days earlier at a campaign rally in Defiance, Ohio, just an hour's drive from a major Jeep plant. "I saw a story today that one of the great manufacturers in this state, Jeep, now owned by the Italians, is thinking of moving *all* production to China. I will fight for every good job in America," Romney declared to enthusiastic applause. The candidate didn't name his source, but earlier that day a blog at the *Washington Examiner* had reported, and the *Drudge Report* had repeated, that Jeep "is considering giving up on the United States and shifting production to China."[2] Those reports pointed back to the same *Bloomberg Business* article which, despite some awkward wording, stated clearly that Chrysler's reentry into Chinese manufacturing would *not* mean "shifting output" from the United States.[3] Even before Romney took the stage in Defiance, a Chrysler vice president had posted an online response to what he called "biased" reports: "Let's set the record straight: Jeep has no intention of shifting production of its Jeep models out of North America to China." The Obama campaign quoted Chrysler prominently in its own response to Romney's charge, e-mailed to reporters after the rally in Defiance. Armed with that direct refutation, papers in Ohio and Michigan characterized Romney's error in stark language. An article in the *Detroit Free Press* opened this way after referring to Romney's "false claim" in the headline: "Republican presidential candidate Mitt Romney repeated a false claim Thursday night that Chrysler Group may move all Jeep vehicle production to China, drawing criticism from the Obama campaign, which said the Michigan native had blatantly skewed a news wire story."[4]

With this narrative already in place and media attention trained on Ohio, the reaction to Romney's new commercial was swift and decisive. "Who Will Do More?" began airing in Toledo on a Saturday. The debunking started the next day at the *Free Press* and the *National Journal*, whose headline announced matter-of-factly, "Romney Ad Wrongly Implies Chrysler Is Sending

Jobs to China."[5] By Tuesday a handful of national outlets as well as the *Toledo Blade*, the *Des Moines Register*, the *Cleveland Plain Dealer*, and the *Columbus Dispatch* had issued fact checks; a blogger at the *Washington Post* marveled at the "brutal headlines" brought on by "Romney's Jeep-to-China lie."[6] By the end of the week, the controversy had been covered across national newspapers and TV networks. "How out there is Mitt Romney?" Jon Stewart asked *Daily Show* viewers. "A car company—the people who convince you you need 'undercoating'—are coming after him for his dishonestly." Meanwhile President Obama turned the controversy into a laugh line in a stump speech:

> You've got folks who work at the Jeep plant who have been calling their employers worried, asking is it true, are our jobs being shipped to China? And the reason they're making these calls is because Governor Romney has been running an ad that says so—except it's not true. Everybody knows it's not true. The car companies themselves have told Governor Romney to knock it off.[7]

Journalists emphasized that Romney had aired the attack despite the controversy over his earlier remark. The *New York Times* addressed the deception in an editorial, a column, and at least five separate news reports as the attack drew new condemnations from Washington and Detroit.[8] A front-page campaign analysis in the *Times* called the TV ad "misleading" in the first sentence, in the reporter's voice.[9] A segment on National Public Radio (NPR) played competing clips from the Romney ad and from Obama's counterattack claiming Jeep was adding jobs in Ohio. The host, Robert Siegel, put the question to an NPR correspondent on the campaign trail: "Well, which is it, Don: they're adding jobs in Ohio or sending them to China?" The reporter left no doubt that the facts were on the president's side. Romney's attack, he explained, reflected the need to "shake things up and really hurt President Obama" in a state that might well decide the election.[10]

The most thorough debunking came from three elite national outlets that specialize in fact-checking political statements: FactCheck.org, PolitiFact, and the *Washington Post*'s Fact Checker. Journalists at these sites had investigated thousands of statements like this one and, as is almost always the case, they reached similar conclusions. All three reconstructed in detail the circumstances of Romney's claim and the wider history of Chrysler's

bankruptcy and bailout.[11] All three found the ad deeply misleading although it avoided the outright falsehood of Romney's original speech. And all three fact-checkers went on to include the episode in their end-of-year reviews of the worst "whoppers" of 2012. PolitiFact named the claim its "Lie of the Year," stressing that even though Jeep issued "a quick and clear denial," Romney made it into a TV commercial that was "brazenly false." The analysis continued:

> And they stood by the claim, even as the media and the public expressed collective outrage against something so obviously false.
>
> People often say that politicians don't pay a price for deception, but this time was different: A flood of negative press coverage rained down on the Romney campaign, and he failed to turn the tide in Ohio, the most important state in the presidential election.[12]

Of course, it is impossible to say precisely what effect the controversy had on the Ohio results. Media and campaign professionals called Romney's attack a strategic blunder for inviting a torrent of negative coverage. "It was a very high-risk strategy, and it backfired," the Obama strategist David Axelrod declared.[13] More interesting than the immediate political impact, though, is what the episode said about prevailing attitudes in political journalism. The immediate and nearly unanimous reaction in the press showed clearly how much has changed in the profession over the last quarter-century, and especially the last decade. It showed how comfortable reporters have become challenging routine political claims—even in straight news reports and often in their own voice. In this way it reflected the growing influence of professional fact-checkers and of the wider fact-checking movement in American news.

This book is about that movement. It tells the story of a group of journalists inventing a new style of political news, one that seeks to revitalize the "truth-seeking" tradition in journalism by holding public figures to account for the things they say. Whether the fact-checkers make any real difference in public discourse is often debated. But their success in building a new journalistic institution can't be denied. Practically every national news organization in the United States offers some kind of political fact-checking today. Dozens of outlets across the country specialize in the new genre ei-

ther as independent websites or as permanent features of a newspaper or news broadcast. All but a handful were established since 2010; scores more have taken root overseas.[14]

Newsrooms have long employed fact-checkers, of course, who verify the information in an article before it goes to print. References to proofreaders first appeared in U.S. periodicals early in the nineteenth century, with copy editors following a century later.[15] Full-fledged fact-checking departments emerged at national magazines in the 1920s and 1930s.[16] The women's section of the classifieds in midcentury newspapers advertised for fact-checkers alongside typists, secretaries, file clerks, and "his girl Fridays." One can find examples from as early as the 1940s of a curious kind of inside-journalism story: rueful letters of praise from journalists to the obsessive, nitpicking fact-checkers who disturb their evenings and weekends and keep them honest.[17] Today these paeans usually come tinged with concern that too many newsrooms no longer practice robust fact-checking.[18] "Being fact-checked is not very fun," the *Atlantic*'s Ta-Nehisi Coates chided in 2012 after an embarrassing episode prompted *Newsweek*—which had shuttered its fact-checking department in the 1990s—to explain that its writers checked their own work. "Good fact-checkers have a preternatural inclination toward pedantry, and sometimes will address you in a prosecutorial tone. That is their job and the adversarial tone is even more important than the actual facts they correct."[19]

This highlights a key aspect of traditional, internal fact-checking: it takes aim at the reporter, not the people being reported on. When a news outlet insists on verifying a source's claims instead of simply reporting them *as* claims, the choice upon discovering a mistake has usually been to fix it or to cut it.[20] In his own ode to fact-checkers, the *New Yorker* writer John McPhee tells the story of the heroic efforts by one of the magazine's researchers to verify a single paragraph in a sixty-thousand-word article—a nuclear physicist's startling anecdote about a Japanese incendiary balloon blown halfway across the world to land on the very reactor making the plutonium that would soon destroy Nagasaki.[21] McPhee had resigned himself to "kill" the passage when, just hours before press time, the fact-checker tracked down another source. Reached at a shopping mall—with the help of the police—the new source confirmed the story and the paragraph lived. The routines of internal fact-checking respond to the imperative to eliminate untruth, not call attention to it.

The new fact-checkers do just the opposite. They investigate claims that are *already* in the news and publish the results as a new story. The fact-checking movement asks political reporters to do something that can be quite uncomfortable for them: to challenge public figures by publicizing their mistakes, exaggerations, and deceptions. It asks them to intervene in heated political debates and decide who has the facts on their side. "After being trained for years not to take sides, you will now have to choose which side is right," instructs a training manual for journalists new to the genre.[22] This kind of fact-checking has precursors in American news, most directly in the "adwatch" reports on campaign commercials that proliferated in the 1990s. Over the last decade, however, political fact-checking has become a staple of professional news reporting in the United States. Fact-checkers now operate year in and year out, not only during elections. They investigate questionable claims wherever they surface, from political memoirs and Facebook posts to speeches on the floor of Congress. And they see themselves as a distinct professional cohort—a self-described fact-checking *movement* within journalism. Increasingly, fact-checkers have their own rules, routines, and "best practices," hammered out in their own conferences and mailing lists. They promote their style of journalism tirelessly and celebrate its achievements vocally. "Fact-checking is not a fad. Fact-checking is not a novelty. It is absolutely here to stay," PolitiFact's publisher declared triumphantly at the first "global summit" of fact-checkers, in 2014. "At PolitiFact, we are reminded of our reach and importance every day as we spread this mantra: Words matter. What a politician says matters. What the government says matters. And when they make a promise or a claim, fact-checking journalists will check it out."[23]

This book investigates fact-checking through the three U.S.-based organizations that have done the most to establish it as a practice and as a movement: FactCheck.org, launched in 2003, and PolitiFact and the *Washington Post*'s Fact Checker, both founded in 2007. These outlets are now well-established voices in national political discourse, cited constantly in venues from NPR to the *Daily Show*. They have won numerous awards for their work; in 2009 PolitiFact received a Pulitzer Prize, U.S. journalism's top honor, for its coverage of the 2008 presidential campaign.[24] (FactCheck.org was also a nominee.) Since then newsrooms around the country, large and small, have

embraced the genre. The major broadcast networks—ABC, CBS, NBC, CNN, Fox, and MSNBC—all regularly offer on-air fact checks, sometimes in partnership with the full-time outlets. NPR coproduced a fact-checking series with PolitiFact and delivers its own fact checks of campaign claims as well as major political events like the State of the Union address. The Associated Press and the *New York Times,* standard-bearers of print journalism, have invested heavily in the new genre and now offer fact checks well beyond campaign season.[25] *USA Today* covers the movement avidly, cites fact-checkers often, and in 2012 began posting videos and reprinting articles directly from FactCheck.org, whose reporters appear in the paper under their own bylines. Only one major national paper, the *Wall Street Journal,* has not embraced the trend.[26]

The fact-checking movement also includes journalists working in local and regional news outlets around the country. These efforts come and go, and no reliable count exists. But serious fact-checking initiatives can be found in traditional newspapers, like the "Truth Needle" at the *Seattle Times* and the *Reno Gazette-Journal*'s "Fact Checker," as well as in online-only outlets like the Voice of San Diego and the Michigan Truth Squad. In 2012 and 2014, local TV newsrooms in markets from Elmira, New York, and Madison, Wisconsin, to Phoenix, Denver, and San Francisco ran segments under names like "Fact Check," "Truth Test," and the popular "Reality Check." Several ventures are the product of unusual local partnerships, like AZ Fact Check, run jointly by the *Arizona Republic,* an NBC affiliate, and the journalism school at Arizona State University. More than a dozen news outlets have signed up to run state-level PolitiFact franchises since the site began to license them in 2010.

Several vital threads come together in the fact-checking movement and the organizations that lead it. Theirs is a story of shifting institutional norms and practices: Fact-checkers enact a deliberate critique of conventional reporting and its practice of objectivity. It is also a story of technological change. Fact-checking as a genre and fact-checkers as news organizations are finely adapted to today's networked news ecosystem. Finally, this is a story about contemporary ways of knowing—about the limits of rational debate in the postbroadcast public sphere. Fact-checkers are a product of the same fractured and fragmented media world they seek to repair. Their work shows every

day how the facts in political life depend on institutional knowledge-building regimes and how difficult public reasoning becomes when those regimes lose authority.

Deciding What's True charts the emergence of a new style of newswork, updating a long tradition of newsroom studies whose landmark is Herbert Gans's *Deciding What's News*. Fact-checkers say political reporting must be more assertive in a world where journalists no longer control access to the public sphere—where they have lost the ability to decide what's news. At the center of the book is a detailed picture of the day-to-day work of fact-checking: how these reporters mine the daily news for claims to investigate, how they find original data and trustworthy experts, how they reach decisive verdicts, and how they respond to their many critics. Fact-checkers think about their audience and their mission in more than one way. They try to balance the daily realities of highly partisan, often vicious political discourse online with their formal commitment to inform a reasoning democratic public. They promise to resolve factual debates in an objective way but also say that, in politics, the truth is not black and white.[27]

This new style of journalism offers a window onto changes in the newsroom and in the wider news ecosystem. Fact-checking combines traditional reporting tools and a commitment to objectivity with the annotative, critical style first associated with bloggers. Fact-checkers practice journalism in the network mode. They link promiscuously to outside news sources, encourage other reporters to cite their work, and strike distribution deals with major media organizations. Fact-checkers have achieved a high profile in elite media-political networks. This affirms their status as objective truth seekers but also places surprising limits on their political critique. Fact-checkers vocally reject "false equivalence" in the news. At the same time, they insist that neither major party has a greater claim to truth in U.S. politics—though their own rulings point to more egregious falsehoods from the right.

Themes and Arguments

Journalism does not simply hold a mirror up to the world: This is the common point of departure for almost all academic research about news production.[28] Journalists deem some events and people newsworthy while ignoring others. They privilege particular sources and viewpoints, fashioning this

material into narratives that fit basic formulas and often reproduce establishment perspectives.[29] They do all of this in ways that vary markedly across different genres or national traditions of journalism. That is, reporters and editors *make* the news—though as Michael Schudson has emphasized, they do not make it up.[30] Fact-checking brings the problem of the institutional basis for public truth claims into sharp relief. The journalists studied in this book make a sincere and remarkably successful effort to get at the facts behind political claims. But facts depend on particular interpretive schemes. They can be unmade in the face of new evidence or a different way of looking at the world. Fact-checking thus highlights the deeper problem with the journalism-as-mirror metaphor: Not just the news but the human institutional reality it reports on is socially constructed.

Three overarching themes run through *Deciding What's True*. The first major focus is on the history and practice of objective journalism in the United States. Organized political fact-checking by professional journalists is barely a dozen years old. The organizations studied here were born into an industry already in crisis, roiled by economic, technological, and professional challenges. They are witnesses to and products of what has been called the "slow-motion collapse of the industrial work model" in journalism.[31] In the last decade a new wave of newsroom studies has examined changes in the production of news in the digital age, in the United States and overseas.[32] The rise of fact-checking as a style of news and a movement in the news adds an important chapter to this story. Fact-checkers practice a kind of journalism that is undeniably of this moment but also claims to revitalize the truth-seeking ideals so vital to the field's self-understanding. Their novel mission returns our attention to the question that animated canonical studies of American journalism by Gaye Tuchman, Michael Schudson, Herb Gans, Daniel Hallin, and others: the understanding and practice of objectivity among professional reporters.

Understanding is just as important as practice in this account. The events and texts brought together here are meant to show how fact-checkers do their work but also how they *talk* about it—to one another and also to fellow journalists, academic researchers, media and political reformers, and the public. A norm like objectivity is more than just a pattern of behavior: "Explaining the *articulation* of a norm is part of explaining the norm."[33] More than that, formally articulated norms and day-to-day practices exist in a sort of dialectic.

Norms inform practices but don't entirely explain or lie "behind" them. Like the rest of us, journalists reinterpret their ideals and sometimes invent new ones as circumstances change. They understand their own work differently depending on the situation and the audience. Thus, an important current in these pages is "metajournalistic" discourse, today and in the past—the conversation journalism has with itself about its successes and failures and about how to adapt to the demands of a changing political world.[34] Reporters began to push at the bounds of objective practice even before the norm became fully entrenched.[35] Fact-checking continues a decades-long turn toward more assertive, analytical reporting that claims the authority to interpret politics for readers.[36] Like earlier journalistic reformers, fact-checkers say their approach corrects for the failures of conventional reporting—although they almost never criticize fellow journalists in published articles. Their understanding of objectivity and their vital ties to other news organizations—two factors more closely related than we might suppose—keep the focus on politicians.

Those links between news organizations point to a second major theme: the shifting media-political environment for news production. Fact-checkers offer an exceptionally clear view of systemic changes in the media in recent decades: the fragmenting of news audiences and the proliferation of journalistic genres and roles that accompanied the rise of first cable and then the Internet as news platforms. The world of more or less "mass" audiences in which journalism became a profession no longer exists. The notion of a single consensus "story" around major events, never completely accurate, is all but defunct. Much of the news ecosystem today is occupied by outlets and formats that exist in relation to other outlets and formats—news offered as an alternative or a corrective to "mainstream" accounts, whether on Fox News or *Democracy Now!*[37] Fact-checkers appreciate these realities as well as anyone working in the media today. They study the media in every story, tracing the origins of political rumors and mapping their spread through the news ecosystem. Their own work sparks frequent controversies that ripple out across media networks.

In this way fact-checking makes explicit the "intermedia" links that traditional reporting practice tends to obscure and that journalism research has dealt with only episodically.[38] Formally, fact-checkers adhere to traditional ideas about journalism's public, writing for an idealized audience of demo-

cratic citizens. They say their mission is simply to provide information, not to change public discourse. At the same time, these journalists pay close attention to their own media footprint. Their work is designed to be incorporated into future news stories. Their authority as objective fact-checkers depends in part on the network of elite media outlets that cite and quote and interview them—relationships that demand effort and attention. Because fact-checking tries to institutionalize a new practice of objectivity, it makes visible the web of material, organizational, and institutional ties in which a norm like objectivity has meaning.

Finally, this book raises the question of how we negotiate public facts in a divided political moment. What counts as a hard fact of political reality for journalists or for the rest of us? What are the limits of public reasoning in a fractured media environment where consensus is rare? Fact-checkers believe in facts. They trust their own methods for seeking them out. But they necessarily operate in a difficult zone between accuracy and truth and admit that the facts in politics can be a matter of interpretation. The debate over Romney's controversial campaign ad captured the paradox well. By one standard, at least, "Who Will Do More?" was accurate—Chrysler *was* going to build Jeeps in China, Romney's defenders pointed out, dismissing the mainstream consensus as evidence of liberal media bias.[39] A fact check by Fox News argued that the real issue was that "after getting bailed out by American tax dollars, a company was deciding to create jobs somewhere *other* than in the US."[40] But professional fact-checkers read the ad differently. They carefully reviewed the economic, policy, and political circumstances around Romney's claim. In that context, the clear intent was to create the impression that the bailout was costing American jobs, when the best evidence indicated the opposite was true. Romney's *message* was a lie even if his words were not.

The question of how to separate fact from opinion—of what kind of truth is even possible in politics—stokes the frequent public controversies over fact-checking. It runs under most of the episodes reviewed in these chapters. It may not have any simple, definitive answer, but studying professional fact-checkers does shed light on the practical realities of building durable facts in today's public sphere. These organizations afford an unusually clear view of the ways that factual reasoning is "embedded"—in material practices, social relations, and systems of value. The world of journalistic work that

emerges here offers little evidence for the existence of incontestable facts or absolute truth. This does not mean, however, that objective journalism's injunction to separate facts from values is pointless. On the contrary, the work of nonpartisan fact-checkers attests every day to the value of a practical commitment to objectivity. On almost every page of this book we find evidence that one argument is not as good as another, that experience and understanding do count for something, and that fair and honest inquiry brings us closer to the truth.

Organization of the Book

The seven chapters that make up *Deciding What's True* are organized into three parts. The first part introduces the fact-checkers and considers fact-checking broadly as a form of journalism, political discourse, and factual inquiry. The key question here is where this new kind of news reporting fits both in today's media world and in the history of professional journalism in the United States. Chapter 1 profiles the three news organizations at the heart of the book: FactCheck.org, PolitiFact, and the *Washington Post*'s Fact Checker. These "ink-stained fact-checkers" form the core of a professional reform movement that sees the new genre as a response to the fragmentation of American public life over the last three decades. However, fact-checking is contested terrain—bloggers, media critics, and politicians all lay claim to it. I survey the fact-checking landscape and introduce the partisan media "watchdogs" who act as a kind of permanent counterpart to journalistic fact-checkers. This wider institutional milieu is vital to understanding how professional journalists define and patrol the boundaries of legitimate fact-checking.

How should we understand fact-checking as a form of factual inquiry? Chapter 2 begins by reviewing the institutional history that has taken shape among practitioners, vital to their sense of fact-checking as a reform movement, and then considers the genre as part of the longer "interpretive turn" in American news. This leads to the question of what separates fact-checkers from other journalists: What are the particular epistemological challenges of investigating claims from public political discourse? Drawing on science and technology studies, I offer a framework based on the surprising instability of "institutional facts." Fact-checkers operate in an institutional world

that is messier than we might think and reach their verdicts by making reasoned judgments about the right standard to apply in a given context. But they work in the open, without the mechanisms that regulate and protect factual inquiry in more specialized areas like science or law. Comparisons to both scientific work and investigative journalism illuminate the ways that judgments of fact and value are woven together while highlighting the special challenge of building durable facts in the political world.

The second part of the book offers a close study of the day-to-day work of the elite fact-checking organizations—how these journalists go about, and think and talk about, the contentious business of deciding what's true. It opens with the story of one of the political lies that first put fact-checkers on the map of mainstream news, the surprisingly persistent rumor that President Obama is not a natural-born U.S. citizen. Chapters 3 and 4 explore the newswork routines that make up this investigative work, from choosing claims to check to "triangulating the truth" when experts disagree. Although the elite fact-checkers differ in some respects, a body of common rules and procedures has taken shape around their fraught enterprise, visible in office work, training sessions, editorial meetings, and public and private documents. The analysis in these chapters highlights how fact-checkers navigate a deeply politicized field of experts and data, how they rely on one another's work, and how they come together in moments of controversy. It also introduces what fact-checkers call the problem of "context"—the difference between literal and implied meaning that always troubles their work.

Chapter 5 turns from institutional routines and norms to the murkier epistemological terrain at the heart of fact-checking. It explores this with a close study of the operation and occasional breakdowns of PolitiFact's "Truth-O-Meter," the fictional instrument that helps to organize and routinize the group's investigations while also giving fact-checkers a way to critique their own methods. I develop these themes and apply the framework introduced in chapter 2 with an extended case study: a fact check of Glenn Beck that I wrote as a participant-observer at PolitiFact and that provoked a public confrontation with the conservative media icon. The case highlights once again what objective factual inquiry means in practice for these journalists: not testing political claims against undisputed facts but rather drawing on judgment and reason—and, inevitably, *values*—to interpret a contested institutional reality and make a coherent argument about where the truth lies.

What kind of difference can fact-checking make in the world? The third part of *Deciding What's True* looks outward to the fact-checkers' relationships with readers, with other reporters, and in the political realm. It begins with a scene from the 2014 midterm elections: one more case in the vivid catalogue fact-checkers cite to show that what they do will never stop politicians from telling lies. While in practice fact-checkers pay close attention to their effect on political discourse, they insist that the only legitimate mission for journalists is to provide information to citizens. Chapter 6 details the fact-checkers' ties to their audience: how they cultivate traffic, how they communicate with readers, and how they reconcile an idealized vision of the public with the charged partisan dynamics that drive attention week by week. But fact-checkers also have a second vital audience. They strive for relevance and achieve their widest impact by managing formal and informal relationships across the media world, especially with high-status news outlets. These relationships magnify the impact of fact-checking while affirming its authority and legitimacy as objective journalism.

The final chapter of *Deciding What's True* takes up the objective status of the fact-checkers as a function of their position in the media-political networks they navigate every day. Their status as objective journalists depends on the way that others use and talk about their work; it is reproduced in formal and informal relationships and in the pattern of outlets that cite and quote and link to them. This helps explain the limits of their truth-telling mission: fact-checkers focus deliberately on discrete claims and individual political actors, carefully avoiding any conclusion that would assign blame for political controversies or for the state of public discourse as a whole. They refuse to talk about the largest conclusion to be drawn from a decade of fact-checking in the United States: Republicans distort the truth more often and more severely than Democrats. I conclude with an epilogue examining recent changes in the world of fact-checking and what they mean for the future of this new genre.

A Note About the Research

My first contact with professional fact-checkers came in 2010 as a graduate student at Columbia University. I was working on a dissertation about the emerging news ecosystem, using a handful of case studies to examine how

major stories unfold today in the critical interplay among different kinds of news venues: elite newspapers, alternative media, talk shows, political bloggers, and so on. Various fact-checking sites—I did not yet understand the vital differences among them—kept turning up in my cases. These organizations seemed to have an especially clear view of online discussion and debate. So late that year I made two trips to Washington, DC, to visit Media Matters for America, PolitiFact, and FactCheck.org (which until 2011 also had its headquarters there). Almost overnight, my project changed shape. More than offering a view of the changing news ecosystem, these fact-checking groups embodied it in their unusual mission, their work practices, and their organizational structures. Fact-checkers produced the kind of link-driven analysis usually associated with political blogging. But more interesting was what seemed to set them apart from bloggers: deep ties to the world of elite journalism and a vocal commitment to its reigning ideal. Even before I'd seen the behind-the-scenes work of investigating political claims, listening to fact-checkers hinted at an occupational world that bridged old and new media in surprising ways.

Deciding What's True is the first in-depth study of the fact-checking movement in professional journalism. It draws on a mix of textual and ethnographic methods: participant observation, formal and informal interviews, content analysis, and some historical research. It is based on more than two hundred hours of fieldwork and interviews conducted over the course of five years in the newsroom and in various public and private forums. I also rely on close textual analysis of published fact checks and other news reports, reading these in light of the historical events they relate to. In practice these methodological lines became quite blurred. The media actors studied here produce a stream of documents—newspaper articles, editor's notes, blog posts, media transcripts, conference transcripts—that defy easy categorization as news texts or ethnographic "texts." Debates about fact-checking often include journalists, media critics, and press scholars engaging with one another directly and publicly. I suggest in the introduction to part 2 that professional fact-checkers perform an unusual variant of the reporter's role as witness: they witness *mediated* events. Similarly, this book reports on an intensely mediated discourse of and about fact-checking.

The initial phase of the research, between 2010 and 2012, spanned fieldwork in Washington, DC, Philadelphia, and another East Coast city that was

the site of professional training for a new PolitiFact partner. I interviewed editors, reporters, and interns at the fact-checking organizations as well as traditional journalists, media critics, partisan fact-checkers, and political strategists. As a researcher embedded with PolitiFact and FactCheck.org, I observed training sessions for reporters and interns, took part in editorial meetings, accompanied fact-checkers on media visits, performed a range of staff and intern duties, and wrote two bylined articles for publication. I sat in with fact-checkers as they met to rule on dozens of political claims from the 2012 presidential cycle and then tracked these rulings as they spread across the media landscape. This mix of news analysis and ethnographic research forms the core of chapters 3, 4, and 5. It allowed me to follow controversies as they unfolded both inside and outside of the newsroom, and to read published articles in light of the actual newswork and internal deliberations that produced them.

At the end of 2011, with funding from the New America Foundation, I co-organized a fifty-person, daylong conference that featured professional fact-checkers as well as journalists, researchers, activists, educators, and foundation officials.[41] This was a rare opportunity for a qualitative researcher—a chance to have my "informants" respond to vital questions about the history, norms, practice, and political effects of fact-checking, in a real-world setting involving important constituencies for their movement. This marked the start of a longer engagement in the fact-checking milieu that informs this book. I've participated in more than a dozen conferences, panel discussions, and other public events with fact-checkers. I helped to plan the first international fact-checking summit, which took place in London in 2014, and presented research there and at the next international conference a year later.[42] I've been involved in several research initiatives that brought together scholars and journalists interested in the growth of fact-checking and the effects it can have in the world. I have also taken part in private forums organized by fact-checkers to solicit feedback about new initiatives. This view of how fact-checkers talk about their work in different contexts and to different constituencies is especially important in framing the analysis in chapters 6 and 7.

Deciding What's True offers a glimpse of a new kind of news at a moment of rapid change. Fact-checking is a moving target—an evolving field that connects the worlds of journalism, academia, and politics. This protean quality

makes it a fascinating subject and has made it possible for me to both observe and participate in different registers as the field has taken shape. (One anthropologist has coined an evocative term for this sort of engagement in an emerging area: "participant figuring out."[43]) At the same time, being involved in the fact-checking milieu in multiple contexts can produce conflicts of interest. For instance, programming the 2011 summit meant trying to meet the priorities of funders—liberal foundations interested in media reform, including George Soros's Open Society Institute—while also pursuing my own research agenda and protecting my relationships with fact-checkers. One major point of tension was the guest list: Some funders felt strongly that the progressive fact-checking outlet Media Matters for America should be present, and professional fact-checkers worried about the political slant of the event (especially given Soros's involvement) and insisted that conservative outlets also be invited if Media Matters was. As the journalists hoped, the solution was not to invite any partisan outlets.[44]

This sort of political tension runs through the fact-checking world and surfaced in many different ways during the research for this book. Another example: although I make a point of it here, during fieldwork I did not challenge these journalists on the question of why Republicans fare worse in their ratings. (At the same time, I made no secret of my own views and invited several key informants to critique an earlier draft.) More generally, it is fair to note that I have had some small role in the discourse this book examines. A major theme of what follows is how fact-checking has been influenced by contact with adjacent professional fields, in particular the academic and nonprofit worlds. However, I hope it will be clear that close engagement in this emerging journalistic world has been a crucial source of insight and perspective, one I try to be reflective about here.

A Note on Consistency

Finally, a note about consistency—my own and that of the journalists this book reports on. Fact-checking remains a contested practice, unclaimed and unstable. What it means is still to some extent up in the air. Various participants and observers, often a difficult line to draw, see it in different ways. This book focuses on the work of professional, journalistic fact-checkers. A major goal—less straightforward than it sounds—is to understand this

emerging phenomenon as they do and to communicate that sense to the reader. But I also try to trace the contours of a wider discourse that sprawls across the media and political worlds.

As noted earlier, fact-checkers talk about their work in different ways depending on the situation and the audience. Their vision of what fact-checking can accomplish is sometimes narrow and sometimes broad. These journalists claim not to want to change people's minds but seize eagerly on any sign that fact-checking makes a difference in the world. They purport to offer decisive factual judgments but also say reasonable people can disagree with their conclusions. They avoid some topics altogether. Throughout this book I draw attention to the limits and internal contradictions of the fact-checking movement. This is where one begins to see the tensions that always inform such a professional project—the difficult questions it raises and the provisional answers fielded by different actors in an emergent area of practice. But I don't mean to present these inconsistencies as a fault or even out of the ordinary. On the contrary, this sort of inconsistency seems basic to human affairs. None of us could get by without it in our professional lives (certainly not in academia). The contradictions we rely on tend to become visible whenever something interesting happens in the life of an organization or a wider professional field—when previously stable and unquestioned arrangements become unsettled.[45]

Fact-checking continues to generate remarkable enthusiasm in the worlds of journalism and politics. It also invites regular critiques, some quite thoughtful, from observers who think fact-checkers confuse public discourse more than they clarify it or that they fall prey to the same sort of false balance they so often condemn.[46] Advocates of meaningful structural change in the conduct or content of American politics may be forgiven for concluding that fact-checking, on the whole, reinforces the centripetal tendencies of U.S. media and political elites—a bipartisan consensus that delegitimizes strong political views as against a more reasonable, "moderate" center. Meanwhile, the earnest people involved in the hard work of political campaigns often don't recognize themselves in the picture that fact-checkers offer of a world ruled by dishonesty and lacking in conviction.[47]

I am sure this book will not completely satisfy such critics, but I hope it sheds light on these complicated questions. It may be worth saying outright that I am sympathetic to the broad fact-checking project, if not always to the

conclusions these journalists reach. I treat the fact-checkers as sincere in their commitments. I see the contradictions they present as something to understand rather than condemn. Fact-checking is a reform movement, but one distinctly tethered to the ideology of professional journalism. These are not outsiders—perhaps the key fact in explaining both their success and the limits of their media and political critique. Like earlier generations of journalistic reformers, fact-checkers aim to revise their profession's reigning ideal in order to defend it.

1

INK-STAINED FACT-CHECKERS

Early in the summer of 2014 an unusual gathering took place at the London School of Economics, near the city center: the first-ever international conference of political fact-checkers.[1] Attendees came from more than twenty countries on six continents. They represented twenty-six different fact-checking operations. Several of these ran out of major national newspapers, such as *Le Monde* in Paris, *El Mercurio* in Chile, and London's *Guardian*. Others had ties to broadcast operations, like the Fact Check desk of the Australian Broadcast Corporation, or like Pagella Politica—literally, "Political Report Card"—an independent site whose research drives a live, weekly fact-checking program on Italy's public broadcaster, RAI. Most, however, were independent websites with no formal ties to news organizations. All but three of the outfits represented had been launched in the last five years.[2]

On the first morning of the summit, the fact-checkers met in a cramped classroom to introduce themselves. Roughly half had backgrounds in journalism, but others came from the worlds of politics, academia, and technology; two were college students in the Czech Republic. Many saw themselves as political reformers. The founder of India's FactChecker.in, which relies on academic researchers to investigate claims and journalists to edit their

work, explained that the initiative grew out of a nationwide anticorruption movement. Egypt's MorsiMeter emerged from a wave of volunteerism that accompanied the Arab Spring, "when people became insanely optimistic and . . . we decided to build a line of tools that helps to empower the average citizen," said its co-creator, an "information activist." Some fact-checkers targeted statements by political figures while others focused on correcting errors in the press or offering a counterpoint to state-run media. Ukraine's StopFake, a site launched just months before the summit that specialized in exposing doctored photographs and bogus news accounts, had the narrowest mission: to counter "Russian propaganda."

Fact-checkers with reporting backgrounds described themselves as seeking to improve the profession. "I believed that journalism in Italy was ill, and fact-checking is good medicine to try to save our journalism," declared the founder of Il Politicometro, another Italian site. The *Guardian*'s Reality Check columnist echoed that view with a comment on her own career: "It rather surprised me that after twenty years of being a reporter I then go off into a little corner of the web site to do what I kind of got *into* journalism to do."[3]

The veterans in the room, comparatively speaking, were the three U.S. fact-checking outlets this book focuses on: FactCheck.org, founded in 2003, and PolitiFact and the *Washington Post*'s Fact Checker, both launched in 2007. Each was represented at the summit by its second generation of leadership (although the founders remained active in the movement and had advised many of the overseas ventures that attended the summit).[4] The modern fact-checking movement arguably began at a much smaller meeting seven years earlier, when the founder of FactCheck.org, Brooks Jackson, invited his two new rivals to a conference on "the rise of media fact-checkers." He welcomed them warmly to the fold; both in turn credited FactCheck.org for inspiring their new ventures. "Well, thanks very much, Brooks, and you're certainly the father of this movement," said Michael Dobbs, the *Washington Post*'s original Fact Checker columnist. "It's great that we're now a fraternity. We're not just ink-stained wretches, we're ink-stained fact-checkers, and we're proud of our calling."[5]

This book tells the story of these ink-stained fact-checkers. As noted in the introduction, over the last decade a surge in fact-checking has swept over American newsrooms, from the major broadcast networks and prestige venues like the *New York Times* and National Public Radio (NPR) to scores of

smaller newspapers, television stations, and online news outlets across the country. While controversial fact checks still draw criticism in some quarters, the profession's standard-bearers have almost universally embraced the new genre. Debates about whether fact-checking is appropriate in objective news reports seem to be settled. In 2012 the incoming public editor of the *Times,* Margaret Sullivan, dedicated her very first post to a full-throated call for more fact-checking, distancing herself from concerns raised by her predecessor just nine months earlier: "Whatever the conclusions, whatever the effectiveness, of challenging facts, the idea that we have to debate the necessity of doing so strikes me as absurd. What is the role of the media if not to press for some semblance of reality amid the smoke and mirrors?"[6]

But the landscape of fact-checking is contested terrain. Its shifting borders include not just professional journalists but also bloggers, media critics, comedians, elected officials, government agencies, corporations, and other public voices. This chapter offers an overview of that landscape, profiling the three elite fact-checking organizations and the professional milieu that has formed around them. This is a milieu grounded in news reporting but with important ties to the academic and nonprofit worlds—links that have helped to shape fact-checking as a subfield of professional journalism. The second half of the chapter profiles a handful of partisan organizations that fact-check from a political point of view, and that frequently criticize the work of sites like PolitiFact and FactCheck.org. These partisan outlets aren't seen as peers by professional fact-checkers. But they figure prominently in the controversies that envelop this new form of journalism. They are essential to understanding the practices and discourse of the fact-checking movement.

Fact-Checking as Political Discourse

For professional journalists, fact-checking refers to a certain set of reporting practices and to the stories these yield. It increasingly denotes a genre, like "news analysis" or "Q&A," involving a more-or-less standard set of conventions for research and presentation. News outlets signal the shift in convention by giving fact checks a special label or assigning them to a designated page—or simply, as the Associated Press (AP) does, by inserting the phrase "FACT CHECK" into the headline.

But in everyday usage, especially online, fact-checking denotes a mode of address. A "fact check" in this wider sense refers to any analysis that publicly challenges a competing account. This mode of public critique helped to define what has been called the Internet's first native genre, the blog. On December 9, 2001, two months after the 9/11 attacks, a conservative blogger incensed at coverage of the U.S. war effort in Afghanistan issued a call to arms against mainstream journalism: "It's 2001, and we can Fact-Check your ass."[7] That phrase left a wide footprint in online discourse among bloggers of all political stripes. It became shorthand for bloggers' practice of line-by-line analysis of questionable claims, especially claims from journalists. It emphatically captured the shared belief that the Internet had changed the balance of power between reporter and reader. "The Internet is also a venue for press criticism," Nicholas Lemann, dean of Columbia's Journalism School, observed in a 2006 *New Yorker* piece. "'We can fact-check your ass!' is one of the familiar rallying cries of the blogosphere."[8] While fact-checking has a distinct history within journalism, it is fair to say that the political fact check represents blogging's legacy to the contemporary public sphere, a discursive move available to anyone participating in online discussion and debate.

Examples abound in contemporary public discourse. For instance, in mid-2014 a Walmart executive issued a public fact check of a column in the previous day's *New York Times*, which had argued that the business model of the world's largest public corporation depends upon various forms of public assistance to supplement its "humiliating wages." Walmart's response treated the *Times* column like a first draft submitted to an editor, marking up the text in red ink and challenging its claims with hand-scrawled margin notes; an introduction explained, "We saw this article in the New York Times and couldn't overlook how wildly inaccurate it is, so we had some fun with it. We hope you will too." The debunking won immediate attention from conservative outlets like the *Daily Caller* and the *Wall Street Journal*. And predictably, within days it drew detailed, point-by-point rebuttals from writers at *Salon* and the *Huffington Post*, the latter titled simply "Fact-Checking Walmart's Fact Check of the New York Times." As is often the case, the dispute turned on earlier fact-checking: how to interpret a PolitiFact piece that questioned similar claims about Walmart.[9]

The language of fact-checking has been taken up with particular enthusiasm in the political world. Fact checks now appear routinely not only from

campaigns but on the websites of Democratic and Republican party organizations and in press releases from congressional committees and individual lawmakers. (A search on congressional web domains turns up more than seven thousand results, with the earliest appearing to date from 2007 and 2008.) These texts often copy the structure of journalistic fact checks, presenting suspect claims in quotes and linking back to multiple sources. "Fact Check: Why What Speaker Boehner Just Said Is Completely Wrong," announced a late 2013 dispatch from Nancy Pelosi, then the House Democratic leader, whose site dedicated a page to fact-checking. To debunk the claim that members of Congress enjoyed a special exemption from new health care rules, the piece cited two conservative sources and a liberal think tank as well as a respected health news site, PolitiFact, and FactCheck.org.[10] Fact-checking by parties and politicians peaks around the same political events that draw journalists, like debates and major speeches. (Since 2012, House Republicans have offered "real-time" fact checks of the president's State of the Union address on a dedicated site.[11]) But it also clearly reflects partisan electoral imperatives. The day Hillary Clinton released *Hard Choices*, a memoir of her tenure as secretary of state that laid the ground for her 2016 presidential run, Republicans (clearly working from an advance copy) responded online with six "volumes" of fact-checking organized around the major foreign policy challenges the book addressed.[12]

Barack Obama's political staff have been avid fact-checkers. During the 2008 presidential race, the Obama campaign unveiled a website called "Fight the Smears" to combat various rumors about the candidate: that he was a Muslim, that he refused to say the pledge of allegiance, that Michelle Obama used the word "whitey" in church, and so on. In 2009, as the debate over health care reform took shape, the White House established a "Reality Check" page to debunk "myths" about the Affordable Care Act.[13] During its first term, the Obama administration published fact checks on areas as diverse as energy policy, the automobile bailout, and the fate of a bust of Winston Churchill, which the president had supposedly sent back to the British—and which Republican presidential contender Mitt Romney promised to return to its rightful place in the White House.[14] For the 2012 race the Obama campaign unveiled a new site, AttackWatch.com, which invited supporters to become part of the president's "Truth Team": "When you're faced with some-

one who misrepresents the truth, you can find all the facts you need right here—along with ways to share the message with whoever needs to hear it."[15]

In this wider sense as a mode of public discourse, fact-checking reflects a several-decade shift: the diminished differentiation or more complex interpenetration of the institutional fields of journalism and politics in the face of technological and economic change.[16] It is well established that rising media abundance has made untenable the gatekeeper role journalists enjoyed in the midcentury heyday of "high-modern" journalism, dominated by three national broadcast networks and powerful metropolitan newspapers.[17] Scholars attribute any number of changes in journalistic practice to this shift; for example, some argue that news organizations abandoned "sacerdotal" approaches to politics in a more competitive and fragmented media environment.[18] But media abundance also invited a proliferation of news roles and formats that intermingled journalism and politics in new ways. This includes blogs, of course, but before that expanded op-ed pages in the 1970s, political talk radio in the 1980s, and a host of debate, analysis, and commentary formats on cable news networks through the 1990s. A thoughtful recent analysis finds that "the space of opinion" in American journalism—meaning venues for elite opinion, analysis, and argument, from policy journals to the *Daily Show*—has expanded dramatically since the introduction of the modern op-ed page at the *New York Times* in 1970. This space of "media intellectuals" bridges the fields of journalism, politics, and academia, the authors argue, and today "is characterized by an incredible diversity of formats linked together in a nested a series of multimedia conversations and citational references."[19]

Professional fact-checkers reject the argument that what they do amounts to commentary or opinion journalism, a criticism they hear often. Their identification as reporters who adhere to the objectivity norm is central to the enterprise. However, fact-checking as a whole belongs to the "space of opinion" in this broader sense of a sphere of elite contestation over politics and policy. In that space, one class of organization deserves special attention as a kind of permanent institutional counterpart to the professional fact-checkers: partisan media "watchdog" groups who publicize, criticize, and sometimes copy journalistic fact-checkers. Four of these watchdog outlets will be introduced after profiles of the elite professional fact-checking organizations.

The Elite Online Fact-Checkers

The first site dedicated to online fact-checking appeared quite early in the history of the web. Snopes.com was founded in 1995 by a pair of self-described "amateur folklorists" with no background in journalism. Today it is the most popular online fact-checker by far, with more than 6 million visitors per month. The site relies on ad support and reportedly yields a comfortable living for Barbara and David Mikkelson, the husband-and-wife team who still run it aided only by a pair of editorial assistants.[20] Snopes.com is not news-driven and addresses itself broadly to online rumors and "urban legends"; major site categories include, for instance, 9/11, Hurricane Katrina, and "Cokelore." However, Snopes.com also debunks rumors and myths from the world of politics, sometimes by citing specialists like FactCheck.org and PolitiFact.[21] Although the founders don't identify as journalists, they have responded to accusations of bias—an elemental feature of the fact-checking world—by pointing to the site's financial independence and political neutrality. The "About" page of Snopes.com declares that David Mikkelson is "wholly apolitical, vastly preferring his quiet scholarly life in the company of his cats and chickens to any political considerations."[22]

The first nonpartisan fact-checker focused strictly on U.S. politics appears to have been Spinsanity, launched in 2001 by three recent college graduates. The site was billed as a "nonpartisan watchdog dedicated to unspinning misleading claims from politicians, pundits and the press."[23] The founders saw themselves as press critics as much as journalists. As one would explain to *Daily Show* host Jon Stewart, "Me and my co-editors were sitting around after the 2000 election, and we were just disgusted with the way it all went, and really disgusted with the media coverage, and disgusted with what happened in Florida."[24] Spinsanity ran through the 2004 presidential campaign, ultimately producing more than four hundred fact checks. Its work was syndicated in media outlets including *Salon* and the *Philadelphia Inquirer* and yielded a best-selling 2004 book about the news media and the Bush White House, *All the President's Spin*. (As told to Stewart, the book described how the administration took advantage of one of the "weaknesses" of the news media: "the objectivity that journalism aspires to, where they won't call a lie a lie.") In a sign of the disciplinary lines that overlap in fact-checking, after Spinsanity closed, one of the founders became a reporter, another

joined the staff of a journalism review, and the third, Brendan Nyhan, became a political scientist who studies political misinformation and fact-checking.[25]

Although not run by professional reporters, both of these early fact-checking sites practiced journalism in the broadest sense: they tried to offer authoritative, factual accounts of issues of public concern and interest.[26] This is particularly true of Spinsanity, which, despite its overt media critique, embraced journalism's core mission of helping people to understand public debates and make informed political choices. This is the mission entailed in what Herb Gans has called "journalism's theory of democracy," the self-understanding of American reporters that places the information they provide at the center of democratic citizenship.[27] The fact-checking operations that followed brought new resources to bear on that mission—larger staffs, professional training and experience, and access to elite media and political networks. But they also shared Spinsanity's critique of conventional journalism, a critique with deep roots within the profession.

FactCheck.org: A "Consumer Advocate" for Citizens

The first dedicated U.S. fact-checking site staffed by professional journalists was FactCheck.org, a nonprofit founded by veteran political reporter Brooks Jackson and communications scholar Kathleen Hall Jamieson. Jackson had begun producing fact-checking segments as a political correspondent a decade earlier at CNN, where he consulted Jamieson's work to refine the format. (This history is reviewed in more detail in the next chapter.) Housed at the Annenberg Public Policy Center at the University of Pennsylvania—its original name was the "Annenberg Political Fact Check"—FactCheck.org announced itself in 2003 as a "nonpartisan, nonprofit, 'consumer advocate' for voters that aims to reduce the level of deception and confusion in U.S. politics."[28] The site was conceived as a project for the 2004 election but proved unexpectedly popular and became a year-round venture. (Its fame grew after being cited by Vice President Dick Cheney—as "factcheck.com"—in a debate with his Democratic challenger John Edwards.)[29]

Today an editorial staff of six, assisted by undergraduate interns, produces roughly five fact checks per week. These often investigate multiple claims related to a current political controversy and may run to several thousand

words. Unlike many newer peers, FactCheck.org does not use a rating system or meter to grade the truth of political claims, but its fact checks describe political deception in blunt language and often deliver sharply worded verdicts. ("Kentucky Sen. Rand Paul claimed that 20 million jobs were created after President Ronald Reagan's dramatic tax cuts in the 1980s, and that this was the 'last time' such job growth took place. Paul is wrong on both counts," began a typical item from mid-2014 titled "Rand Paul's Supply-Side Distortion.") The group focuses its analysis on "major U.S. political players," meaning in practice government officials, electoral candidates, and various party organizations, including outside groups such as political action committees. However, it also investigates online rumors and chain e-mails related to political themes.

The FactCheck.org site carries no advertising and relies on foundation support. Funding from the Annenberg Foundation averaged almost $750,000 since 2010 but began to fall off in 2014, as a ten-year grant establishing the site came to an end.[30] In 2010 the organization also began accepting private donations, which totaled $139,000 in 2014, an election year, and $58,000 the following year. FactCheck.org does not take money from corporations, labor unions, or advocacy groups. In 2011 the Annenberg Public Policy Center launched FlackCheck.org, a companion site focused on "political literacy." The venture is separately staffed and operated but relies on FactCheck.org's research to produce videos and analysis highlighting "patterns of deception" in political speech.

Its nonprofit status and ties to a research university set FactCheck.org apart to a degree from peers based in traditional newsrooms. A mission statement explains that the site aims to apply "the best practices of both journalism and scholarship"; staff sometimes invoke an academic mindset, for instance, to explain their refusal to use "unscientific" rating systems.[31] More strikingly, the site's copyright policy invites anyone to reproduce or distribute its fact checks free of charge, so long as appropriate credit is given and "editorial integrity" is preserved. In this way, foundation support helps to resolve the usual tension between journalism's democratic and commercial goals, ensuring the widest possible audience for the group's fact-checking. "Being stolen or plagiarized is fine with us," founder Brooks Jackson told me. Eugene Kiely, who succeeded Jackson as director in 2013, echoed this view: "Our copyright essentially says 'steal our stuff.'" FactCheck.org has established informal dis-

FactCheck.org Fellowship Program

FactCheck.org, the award-winning political website at the Annenberg Public Policy Center of the University of Pennsylvania, is now accepting applications for its 2011–2012 fellowship program. The next class of fellows will be trained during an eight-week, paid summer program at FactCheck's offices at APPC from June 5–July 30. Those who are trained this summer must agree to work 10 to 15 hours per week at FactCheck.org during the fall and spring semesters, if their work merits continued employment.

We are a nonpartisan, nonprofit "consumer advocate" for voters. The fellows at FactCheck.org help our staff monitor the factual accuracy of claims made by political figures in TV ads, debates, speeches, interviews and news releases. They help conduct research on such claims and write articles for publication on our website under the guidance and supervision of FactCheck.org staff. The fellows must have an ability to write clearly and concisely, an understanding of journalistic practices and ethics, and an interest in politics and public policy. The fellows also must be able to think independently and set aside any partisan biases.

The deadline for applications is Feb. 28. For more information, contact FactCheck.org Philadelphia Director Eugene Kiely at Eugene.kiely@factcheck.org.

FACTCHECK.ORG
ANNENBERG POLITICAL FACTCHECK

THE ANNENBERG
PUBLIC POLICY CENTER
OF THE UNIVERSITY OF PENNSYLVANIA

FIGURE 1.1 A call for interns for FactCheck.org's fellowship program describes the group's mission and indicates the qualities it looks for in student interns, including "the ability to set aside any partisan biases." *Source: Courtesy of FactCheck.org.*

tribution partnerships to increase its reach, for instance, with *USA Today*, *Yahoo News*, and the *Huffington Post*, which frequently reproduce its articles.[32]

Despite these ties to the academic and philanthropic worlds, though, FactCheck.org identifies unmistakably as a journalistic enterprise. The site has won numerous journalism awards and was a nominee for a Pulitzer Prize. Its editorial staff come almost exclusively from backgrounds in political reporting. (Both Jackson and Kiely are veteran political reporters. The former

worked for CNN, the *Wall Street Journal*, and the AP, and the latter for the *Philadelphia Inquirer* and *USA Today*.) This core identification is reaffirmed constantly in both public and private settings. Thus, for instance, a call for student interns stressed that they must be able to "think independently and set aside any partisan biases" (see figure 1.1). To the dismay of some, interns are discouraged from participating in political causes or events or from adorning their workspace with political materials.[33]

PolitiFact: Fact-Checking as a Database

PolitiFact appeared in May 2007 as a joint project of the *St. Petersburg Times* and its then-sister publication, the *Congressional Quarterly*. The nonprofit Poynter Institute owns the newspaper, now called the *Tampa Bay Times*. But both the *Times* and PolitiFact operate as commercial, ad-supported media ventures, and select fact checks run in the print edition of the paper. (*CQ*'s role in the site diminished quickly, and in 2009 it was sold to the Economist Group.) The idea for PolitiFact came from Bill Adair, then the newspaper's Washington bureau chief. He proposed it to his editors—with the tentative name "Campaign Referee"—as a version of FactCheck.org built around a database, rather than a blog. "My idea was, take what FactCheck was doing and package it in a way that was less of a blog, and takes advantage of the web," Adair explained. "By building it from scratch we were able to create what I think is truly a new form of journalism."[34]

PolitiFact's database hinges on its trademarked "Truth-O-Meter," which scores every political claim along a six-point scale running from "True" to "Pants on Fire." The site's original mission statement played up this difference from its predecessor: "PolitiFact . . . is bolder than previous journalistic fact-checking efforts because we'll make a call." PolitiFact also differs from FactCheck.org in the targets of its fact-checking, who from the outset have included not just political but media figures: pundits, analysts, columnists, editorial writers, and so on. In 2013 the organization spun off PunditFact, a sister site dedicated to claims by media personalities. Truth-O-Meter verdicts become part of a database that can be accessed according to the topic, the rating, and, crucially, the speaker, making it possible to look up the lifetime record of public figures tracked by the site. "This is a working database and over time it will grow more valuable," the site promised at launch.[35]

By 2015 that database had grown to more than five thousand fact checks. Today seven editors and reporters produce roughly twenty items per week for PolitiFact's national site and for PunditFact. Since 2010 PolitiFact has also licensed its brand and its methodology to state media partners—typically flagship newspapers—who pay roughly $30,000 the first year and annual renewals of about $10,000. State franchises operate independently after being trained in the Truth-O-Meter method. They commit to producing several items per week, which run on a dedicated state page at the PolitiFact site and become part of the master Truth-O-Meter database. In return, state media partners sell advertising against their stories at the site and have the right to carry PolitiFact stories in their print editions or to syndicate them to other news outlets in their state.[36] The franchise network grew quickly in its first two years but saw defections after the 2012 presidential race. As the next election approached, it began to recover, however, and by the end of 2015 included fourteen states: Texas, Florida, Georgia, Rhode Island, Wisconsin, Virginia, New Hampshire, Missouri, California, Iowa, Arizona, Nevada, Colorado, and Ohio.[37]

Despite its origins in a commercial newspaper, it would be a mistake to understand PolitiFact mainly as a for-profit venture. Ad revenue at the site has never yielded more than a fraction of the costs of what is a staff-intensive form of journalism. Likewise, from the start of its state licensing program, PolitiFact acknowledged that the "modest amount of revenue" from the media partnerships would not yield a profit and was, instead, a way to defray costs while increasing the audience for PolitiFact's fact-checking. Asked about revenues after the first partners joined in 2010, Adair stressed the site's journalistic mission: "Ultimately, this is a public service play."[38] That sense of mission runs through training sessions for new state partners, who are invited to practice a more demanding and more honest form of journalism. In editor's notes the group often celebrates the depth of the Truth-O-Meter database and the growth of the PolitiFact network around the country. Reporters and editors from across the network gather each year for a celebration they call "PolitiFact Palooza."

Beginning in 2010 PolitiFact sought to build ties to the nonprofit sector, where a number of foundations have supported fact-checking and research about fact-checking as a means of improving the quality of public discourse. These efforts bore fruit in 2013 with a $625,000 grant from the

Ford Foundation and the Democracy Fund that financed the launch of PunditFact.[39] The money allowed PolitiFact to add three full-time fact-checkers to its national staff. It also came with a requirement to "analyze the reach and impact" of the new venture, a common practice in the philanthropic world.[40] This evaluation requirement would be fulfilled by the Poynter Institute rather than by PolitiFact directly. Still, it illustrates a recurring theme: how the disciplinary lines that cross in fact-checking—journalistic, philanthropic, academic—push professional reporters to think and talk about their work in new ways.[41]

The Fact Checker: Translating Political "Code Words"

In September 2007, four months after PolitiFact appeared, the *Washington Post* unveiled its own dedicated fact-checking venture. Political reporter Michael Dobbs, who had retired from the *Post* but was invited back to cover the presidential race, proposed the Fact Checker as a way to correct "some of the flaws in political reporting, the focus on the horse race and the 'he said, she said.'" He envisioned the column awarding some sort of "Pinocchio" prize to dishonest politicians, perhaps with a nose that grew to match the scale of the deception.[42] As Dobbs would later write, he prepared for a heated discussion with his editors: "Was it the place of a *Post* reporter to referee campaign debates, and rap erring politicians over the knuckles? Would we be sacrificing our cherished 'non-partisan' status and 'balance' if we came down on one side or the other in factual arguments?"[43]

Instead the idea met with swift approval. The Fact Checker ran on the *Post*'s website through the presidential election, with an "unofficial quota" of one item per day. A dozen or so columns also ran in the print edition of the newspaper, usually a few pages into the "A" section. The ratings system awarded political claims from one to four "Pinocchios" depending on the degree of distortion; true claims earned a "Gepetto" checkmark. Three months into his tenure Dobbs invented a new category, "True but False," for claims that are "technically accurate" but nevertheless "create a misleading impression that can be as powerful as an outright lie."[44] Looking back on the experience, Dobbs has said that he felt overwhelmed by the "deluge of misinformation," which required him to become an "instant expert" in areas

he had never covered before, and that he was able to do more probing reporting during the 2004 race by focusing on a handful of issues.[45]

In 2011 the *Post* revived the Fact Checker as a permanent feature under Glenn Kessler, a longtime politics and policy reporter with the newspaper. Kessler has called this an ideal assignment for a journalist with his background in covering most major policy areas, and especially with experience on the diplomatic and foreign affairs beat, long friendly to analytical reporting.[46] The column's mission statement describes fact-checking as a form of explanatory journalism: "We will seek to explain difficult issues, provide missing context and provide analysis and explanation of various 'code words' used by politicians, diplomats and others to obscure or shade the truth." The rebooted Fact Checker left the Pinocchio scale intact and, at the end of 2011, began compiling average Pinocchio scores for major presidential candidates, a small step toward the "database" approach used by PolitiFact. At the same time, whereas his predecessor occasionally investigated claims from the opinion pages, Kessler hews more narrowly to statements "by political figures and government officials."[47]

Kessler and one other fact-checker produce roughly one item per day for the *Post*'s website, with a column also running in the news section of the print newspaper each Sunday. In 2013 the newspaper unveiled an experimental "instant fact-checking" platform called Truth Teller, funded with a $50,000 grant from the Knight Foundation. The application used an algorithm to identify political claims in recorded speech from video clips and matched these in real time to fact checks from the *Post* as well as PolitiFact and FactCheck.org, displaying the verdict as the video ran.[48] As part of the project, Kessler gained an additional assistant to help produce prerecorded versions of Fact Checker columns for the newspaper's video outlet, PostTV. The rationale mirrored that for FlackCheck, FactCheck.org's companion site: to animate fact-checking in a compelling format that will reach a wider audience than lengthy written analyses.[49]

The Fact Checker differs from its two national peers in its day-to-day ties to a traditional newsroom. The contrast with PolitiFact is notable: While both ventures are attached to print newspapers, PolitiFact runs its own website and is headquartered in a Washington bureau dominated by fact-checkers. Meanwhile Kessler works out of the *Post*'s newsroom, publishes on its

website, and does not operate the Fact Checker as a business unit with its own revenue. In this way the venture more closely resembles fact-checking initiatives by other national news outlets like the *New York Times*, the AP, and NPR. However, the Fact Checker is a year-round operation not focused on campaign season. Kessler and his staff work on fact-checking full time, unlike political reporters assigned to check an occasional speech or debate. And, just as important, both Kessler and his predecessor have participated avidly in the professional discourse that argues for the importance of this uncomfortable and often controversial style of journalism. For these reasons, it makes sense to consider the Fact Checker in the same terms as dedicated outlets like PolitiFact and FactCheck.org.

Reformers in the Journalistic Field

These three dedicated fact-checking outlets, with one or two counterparts at traditional news organizations, have become a recognized professional cohort in elite journalism. They meet several times a year at conferences or private gatherings that bring together journalists, researchers, and funders interested in the fact-checking phenomenon. They appear together on panels and are quoted in the same articles. "Call it the Fact-Checking Summit," announced a journalism review's report on a mid-2012 meeting at the National Press Club, continuing:

> The key players in journalism's burgeoning fact-checking movement were on the scene: pioneer Brooks Jackson, who launched and runs FactCheck.org; Bill Adair, editor of the Pulitzer-winning PolitiFact, the Tampa Bay Times initiative that also has regional branches around the country; Glenn Kessler, who writes the The Fact Checker for the Washington Post; and longtime D.C. correspondent Jim Drinkard, who oversees accountability reporting for the Associated Press.[50]

The three elite fact-checkers see themselves as a kind of fraternity. "We're friendly," a group of state PolitiFact reporters were told during a training session—an unusual lesson for journalists to hear about their main rivals.[51] The three sites cover much of the same material, cite one another in their work, and band together against their critics. As noted earlier, when his new

counterparts emerged in 2007, FactCheck.org founder Brooks Jackson held a meeting to celebrate the surge in fact-checking. "I am so glad . . . that we have company in this area now," he declared, calling PolitiFact "a breath of fresh air" and praising the skills and experience the *Washington Post* brought to its venture.[52] When Kessler took over the *Post*'s fact-checking column in 2011, Jackson and Adair took him to lunch in Washington, welcoming the new fact-checker to their very small club.[53] "I wouldn't say we're competitors, I think we view each other as part of the same peer group," Kessler would later explain in a PBS interview.[54]

These three organizations are rivals joined in a very self-conscious project of pioneering a new kind of journalism. They offer a reformer's critique of conventional political news, rejecting what is often called "false balance" or "he said, she said" reporting.[55] "I am a journalist of many years—a recovering 'he said, she said' reporter, I suppose," Jackson joked at the opening of a fact-checking summit in late 2011.[56] That reformist identity has taken shape in critical venues like conferences and journalism reviews which, as Barbie Zelizer noted two decades ago, help to "build authority for practices not emphasized by traditional views of journalism."[57] This book draws heavily on such metajournalistic discourse and especially on a series of public and private meetings of fact-checkers over the last decade (listed in table 1.1). These gatherings have been vital to the fact-checking movement in three ways: first, as opportunities for the journalists involved to recognize their shared mission as a movement; second, as sites to negotiate the tensions and contradictions implicit in that movement; and third, as sources of cross-pollination between journalism and adjacent fields, like academia and the nonprofit world, which have been important sources of financial and intellectual support.[58]

On first analysis, fact-checking appears to be simply another specialized journalistic subfield, like sports reporting, with its own subset of norms and practices within the wider professional field. Many practitioners would describe it this way. What sets it apart is a self-conscious orientation to the rest of the field: fact-checkers seek fairly openly to *fix* political journalism by introducing new practices, revising prevailing norms, and building institutional resources for what they see as an essential and undervalued form of public-affairs reporting. Like earlier instances of journalistic "field repair," such as the public journalism movement of the 1990s, fact-checking justifies

TABLE 1.1 Building a Movement: Fact-Checking Events Since 2007

Event	Sponsor	Place	Date
Pants on Fire: Political Mendacity and the Rise of Media Fact-Checkers	Annenberg Public Policy Center	Washington, DC	November 9, 2007
The Future of Fact Checking	City University of New York	New York	November 15, 2011
Fact-Checking in the News	New America Foundation	Washington, DC	December 14, 2011*
"The Facts of Political Life"	New America Foundation	Washington, DC	February 28, 2012*
Truthiness in Digital Media	Harvard Berkman Center	Cambridge, MA	March 6–7, 2012*
"Fact Checking the 2012 Election: Views from the Trenches"	Annenberg Public Policy Center	Washington, DC	May 22, 2012
Countering Misinformation and Strengthening Online Discourse	New America Foundation	Washington, DC	February 8, 2013*
"Challenges for the Fact-Checking Movement: 2013–2016"	New America Foundation	Washington, DC	March 5, 2013
"Fast Food & Fact-Checking: Lessons from PolitiFact"	South by Southwest	Austin, TX	March 11, 2013
"Fact-Checking Goes Global"	South by Southwest	Austin, TX	March 10, 2014
"Fact-Checking Goes Global"	International Journalism Festival	Perugia, Italy	May 3, 2014
"API Fact-Checking Scholars' Meeting"	American Press Institute	Washington, DC	May 30, 2014*
Global Fact-Checking Summit	Poynter Institute	London	June 9–10, 2014*
Latam Chequea	Chequeado	Buenos Aires	November 6–8, 2014
Truth in Politics 2014: A Status Report on Fact-Checking Journalism	American Press Institute	Washington, DC	December 10, 2014*
"Examining PunditFact and Its Role in Journalism"	Poynter Institute	Washington, DC	February 10, 2015*
Global Fact-Checking Summit	Poynter Institute	London	July 25–25, 2015*

Note: There may be other fact-checking events since 2007 not included in this list.

* Events attended by the author.

its unconventional approach in terms of a fundamental failure of the profession.[59] A recurring theme in the chapters that follow is how their common mission both binds rival fact-checkers together and makes their emerging subfield open to influences and discourses from outside of journalism.[60]

Contrasts and Convergence

The three elite U.S. fact-checkers are not identical. Comparing their organizational backgrounds and structure helps to account for some of the differences in their approaches. Consider the contrast between FactCheck.org and PolitiFact. Foundation support and university ties at the older outlet anchor what its own journalists describe as a straightforward, no-frills approach to fact-checking. For instance, FactCheck.org vocally rejects the ratings systems developed by its newer rivals. Brooks Jackson has said there's no "academically respectable way" to rate the truth of political claims—"We're part of an Ivy League university here"—and that he sees meters mainly as marketing tools: "It's flashy, it's eye-catching, it gets people involved, and it helps sell it to an audience that might find our stuff more pedantic."[61] In contrast, PolitiFact's status as an independent, revenue-seeking business unit has encouraged a more entrepreneurial mindset. From the outset the site eagerly courted publicity (by one account, Bill Adair gave more than two hundred on-air interviews during the group's first year) and developed partnerships with broadcasters to promote its work.[62] This media-hungry approach dovetailed with its easily citable Truth-O-Meter, a device that reflects both journalistic and business goals. The humorous rating system makes PolitiFact's analysis easier for readers to digest—it adds flavor to what Adair calls "eat your vegetables" journalism—and also helped to build a national brand.[63] The site's media profile eased the launch of the PolitiFact franchise network, built around licensing the trademarked Truth-O-Meter. Running that network, in turn, has shaped journalistic practice, for instance, by requiring PolitiFact to codify its methodology in order to train new fact-checkers and to promote consistency across franchises.

At the same time, the field of professional journalism is ample and diverse enough to account for the differences between these groups. It would be a mistake to see a strong causal link between funding arrangements (or other organizational features) and newsroom practice among the fact-checkers.

While editors at FactCheck.org attribute their approach to a scholarly mindset, truth meters are used by other university-linked fact-checkers, such as AZ Fact Check. Conversely, many traditional news organizations such as the AP and the *New York Times* have been reluctant to use rating systems, notwithstanding the example set by the *Washington Post* and the *Tampa Bay Times*. In a 2012 panel discussion with his fact-checking peers, Jim Drinkard, accountability editor at the AP, pointed to the inherent "squishiness" of metered ratings.[64] It is equally hard to trace a clear link between organizational roots and the use of a meter among overseas fact-checkers.[65]

In this respect, organizational circumstances influence journalistic work mainly by shaping the context within which editorial choices should make sense. Being based at an Ivy League university adds to the institutional-cultural repertoire the journalists at FactCheck.org can draw on to understand and justify their approach to fact-checking and in this way has shaped their identity and their practice. But the group can also fairly be described, despite its nonprofit status and academic home, as journalistic traditionalists—an identity both Jackson and his successor, Eugene Kiely, embrace. "I'm old school," Jackson told me, a phrase he has used in other interviews.[66] Different rationales would have been available to stay away from rating political claims had FactCheck.org taken root not at a university but in one of the media outlets Jackson worked for previously.

Indeed, while important differences persist, the three elite fact-checkers have shown clear signs of convergence in both business and editorial practice. Editors at FactCheck.org have remarked several times on the sharper deadline pressure the group faced once its national rivals appeared; in 2009 a major site redesign introduced the "FactCheck Wire" for shorter, more timely articles. Both FactCheck.org and the *Post*'s Fact Checker have taken pages from the highly visible PolitiFact. Since 2012, for instance, FactCheck .org has sought to boost its public profile with an aggressive campaign to partner with print and broadcast news outlets.[67] And, as noted earlier, soon after relaunching Fact Checker, Glenn Kessler took a step toward PolitiFact's database model with a "Pinocchio Tracker," which compared the fact-checking records of major presidential candidates.[68] Meanwhile, and perhaps most important in terms of fact-checking's development as a journalistic institution, PolitiFact and Fact Checker have begun to benefit from philanthropic interest in fact-checking, following the path laid down by FactCheck.

org. This sort of convergence may or may not be the result of deliberate imitation in particular cases, but it unfolds against the backdrop of a set of common constraints—economic, editorial, political—shaping the decisions these organizations take.[69]

This is arguably what it means for a distinct field or subfield of practice to take shape: practitioners begin to identify with one another, even as rivals, and to identify common techniques, concerns, values, and so on. Even where contrasts persist, fact-checkers increasingly have a common language for talking about those differences and what they mean, developed over years of contact in both public and private settings. Take again the question of rating claims, the most visible and contentious dividing line in the fact-checking world. In a 2012 farewell post looking back on nearly a decade at the helm of FactCheck.org, Brooks Jackson mixed praise for his fellow fact-checkers with sharp words about the pitfalls of "inflexible rating systems."[70] The post identified a trade-off that fact-checkers who use ratings systems have conceded openly: meters draw increased attention and simplify analysis that can be forbiddingly dense but also seem to hold out the promise of a mechanical objectivity that defies the messy reality of journalistic fact-checking. (Even the editor of the *Tampa Bay Times*, PolitiFact's parent newspaper, has called the Truth-O-Meter a journalistic "gimmick," albeit a valuable one.)[71] Rating systems bring the tensions in fact-checking into sharp relief and have made PolitiFact and the Fact Checker the focus of intense criticism from both political figures and fellow journalists.

The tradeoffs of rating systems became a central theme of the 2014 Global Summit of fact-checkers. Reprising a debate from an earlier journalism conference, Bill Adair staged a "steel-cage death match" with the director of Full Fact, a London-based fact-checking outlet that abandoned its own five-point rating scheme (indicated by a magnifying lens) as lacking precision and rigor. Will Moy explained that Full Fact decided to forgo "higher attention" in favor of "long-term reputation," adding that "a dodgy rating system—and I'm afraid they are inherently dodgy—doesn't help us with that." PolitiFact's two top U.S. rivals also took part in the debate, which Adair opened with a light-hearted vow to convert the new director of FactCheck.org to his way of thinking.[72] After someone wondered why the scales tend to be comical, Glenn Kessler defended the *Washington Post*'s rating system: "Those Pinocchios, at least in Washington, have tremendous power. I mean

I have members of Congress that call me up, directly, and say, 'What do I need to do to stop getting Pinocchios?' " Of roughly two dozen fact-checking groups in the room, just over half used some sort of meter to assess claims or political promises, and forceful arguments were offered both for and against. But the most striking feature of the discussion was the easy agreement about the virtues and limits of rating claims and the repeated affirmation that the fact-checking world needs multiple approaches.[73]

A major goal of the meeting was to establish an association of fact-checkers from around the world. This promised to be a delicate task. Many different kinds of organizations were present, including a dozen without strong ties to journalism. Surprising methodological differences emerged over the course of the two-day meeting. Some overseas fact-checkers were astonished to learn that their U.S. counterparts always call the subjects of their investigations before publishing; they wondered whether this invites reprisals, or gives public figures the chance to change their story. Meanwhile, veteran journalists in the room couldn't believe that some academically minded peers checked every single factual claim in a debate or speech rather than just the interesting ones. With so many different understandings of what counts as a fact check or a fact-checker, the organizers would have to decide who qualified for membership in the new association. Only one clear principle emerged: Partisan fact-checkers with direct ties to political parties or other interest groups could not take part.[74]

Fact-Checking from a Political Point of View

As noted earlier, fact-checking offers a clear illustration of the institutional blurring or mixing of the media and political fields in recent decades. This is true in at least two important ways. First, journalism that challenges public statements makes it harder in practice for reporters to claim a clear separation from political actors. To contest a claim in public is a political act. It invites political criticism and risks drawing reporters into partisan fights—precisely the kinds of fights that the defensive tactics of objective journalism, such as "he said, she said" framing, are designed to avoid.[75] (It is worth noting that the day-to-day work of fact-checking bears at least a superficial resemblance to the opposition research that has long been a feature of U.S.

political campaigns.) Of course one can argue, as fact-checkers do, that true objectivity means taking the side of truth even when that favors one point of view. But this produces a more "political" journalism in the sense of reporting that advances an argument and predictably sparks counterarguments.

Second, fact-checking as a genre has invited particularly exuberant forms of media activity from political actors and from organizations that bridge the media and political spheres. It is an active site of what some political communications scholars call the "mediatization" of politics, meaning the tendency for political activities or processes—campaigning, activism, and etc.—to "assume media form."[76] This is sometimes described as the penetration of "media logic" into other spheres of activity: to pursue political goals in an organized and strategic fashion means, increasingly, to think and behave like a media producer.[77] This sort of logic can be read, for instance, in strategies used by political actors to go "around" traditional news media. (Journalists and media critics have objected loudly to the use of such strategies by the Obama administration: "They become publishers, they become journalists, they become their own advertising agency," an ABC White House reporter complained in an NPR segment on this question.)[78] The mediatization of politics is arguably neither as new nor as complete as the most overheated rhetoric suggests.[79] Nevertheless, it offers a useful frame for thinking about fact-checking by political actors who very visibly imitate journalistic techniques and presentation even as they challenge professional journalism.

Beyond journalism, one area where fact-checking finds institutional purchase—where it is practiced in a sustained and organized way—is among press critics. Media criticism, like fact-checking, links journalism to adjacent professional fields. In the United States, it has two main centers of gravity. What might be called establishment press criticism straddles the border between professional journalism and media scholarship. It is embodied by publications like the *Columbia Journalism Review* and the *American Journalism Review*, both based in schools of journalism. Various publications and centers occupy different points along the spectrum between reporting and academia; Harvard's Nieman Journalism Lab, to take another example, takes a more scholarly approach than the established professional reviews. However, all of these venues offer a space for professional self-examination and critique—for instance, of "he said, she said" reporting—and have helped to incubate the

fact-checking movement. (Two articles in the *American Journalism Review*, the first from 2004, appear to have been the first to use the phrase "fact-checking movement."[80]) In addition to covering and generally celebrating the new genre, establishment press critics sometimes offer their own fact checks. For instance, the *Columbia Journalism Review*'s "Campaign Desk" site, which first appeared in 2004 and has called itself "the conscience of the political press," often evaluates political claims in the course of scrutinizing campaign coverage.[81]

A separate and quite vibrant tradition of media criticism in the United States emerges from the political world and has yielded organized fact-checking efforts on both the left and the right. Partisan media watchdog groups—early examples are the conservative Accuracy in Media, established in 1969, and its liberal counterpart Fairness & Accuracy in Reporting, operating since 1986—engage in a shifting mix of media and political activities. They conduct research and issue reports documenting media bias. They produce various forms of in-house media that report on the news industry, such as newsletters, blogs, and sometimes video segments. And they publicize all of this work through interviews and articles in conventional news outlets. In this respect, they might be considered a subset in the wider category of American "think tanks" that, as Thomas Medvetz argues, bridge the political, academic, economic, and media fields, drawing resources selectively from each of these worlds in order to negotiate institutional challenges.[82] Like other kinds of think tanks, media watchdog groups have adapted to the digital media environment by emphasizing media production and newslike story forms. This includes regular efforts at fact-checking.

Media Watchdogs as Fact-Checkers

Any number of partisan media critics engage regularly with the professional fact-checkers, from lone bloggers to writers with well-known partisan journals like the *Weekly Standard*, *Washington Monthly*, and the *American Prospect*. One site, PolitiFact Bias, exists solely "to expose the defective fact-checking apparatus at PolitiFact, with special focus on the problems that help show PolitiFact's marked ideological bias."[83] But four established media watchdog groups deserve special attention as critics of professional fact-checkers and sources of partisan fact-checking.

Accuracy in Media

Founded in 1969 by Reed Irvine, then an economist with the Federal Reserve, Accuracy in Media (AIM) established a prototype for media watchdog organizations that would follow on the left as well as the right. The group can be seen as part of the wider network of "movement conservatism" that emerged to challenge the orthodoxies of the liberal welfare state in the wake of Barry Goldwater's disastrous 1964 presidential campaign. AIM was an early beneficiary of conservative philanthropic networks and helped to develop the critique of the "liberal media" that has been an anchor of modern conservatism. In 2009, the last year for which figures were available, the nonprofit took in $500,000 in contributions.

AIM focuses squarely on identifying bias in the news, describing its mission as "to promote accuracy, fairness and balance in news reporting."[84] Its signal campaigns over more than four decades include forcing PBS to air a rebuttal to the network's thirteen-part 1983 documentary on the Vietnam War; a long effort to "Impeach Dan Rather" (or "Can Dan") by exposing the CBS anchor's alleged leftward slant; and a critique of the *New York Times*'s reporting on the "El Mozote" massacre perpetrated by the U.S.-backed military regime in El Salvador, which prompted the paper to reassign its correspondent there.[85] While distinct from contemporary fact-checking, these efforts point up the sometimes hazy line between checking facts and finding bias. The campaign against the *Times*'s reporter, for instance, turned in part on challenging the facts of his account of the massacre (details that would be vindicated a decade later). Similarly, AIM's day-to-day output often questions claims in news reports and uses the language of fact-checking—but with journalists rather than the sources they quote as the target of the investigation. As a 2014 *AIM Report* piece on the *Times*'s Benghazi coverage summarized, "Accuracy in Media has, time and again, disproven these points. But, given the misinformation put forward by the Grey Lady, the facts bear repeating."[86]

Media Research Center

Founded in 1987 by the conservative activist L. Brent Bozell, the Media Research Center (MRC) has succeeded AIM as the most active nexus of

conservative media criticism. A mission statement explains that "MRC's sole mission is to expose and neutralize the propaganda arm of the Left: the national news media." In 2013 the group took in more than $13 million in contributions and dedicated $4 million to its "news analysis" division, claiming a staff of sixty-three dedicated to "monitoring, analyzing, and reporting the most egregious examples of media bias." As with AIM, the MRC's media analysis has often involved a kind of fact-checking through the lens of conservative politics. Thus, in a report from the mid-1990s, MRC researchers reviewed a year of Medicare coverage in national newspapers and magazines and turned up 1,060 "errors"—meaning references to program "cuts" that were in fact only reductions in growth. The MRC's monthly newsletter *MediaWatch*, published until 1999, featured a "Janet Cooke Award" (named after the *Washington Post* Pulitzer Prize recipient who was later exposed as a fabricator) to "distinguish the most outrageously distorted news story of the month."

In 2005 the MRC launched a separate site, NewsBusters, to provide a rapid-fire outlet for its analysts, who use banks of digital video recorders to monitor the daily news diet on broadcast and cable networks. The site has roughly a dozen people on staff, assisted by numerous outside contributors, posting twenty to thirty brief items each day in response to mainstream news accounts. NewsBusters scored a major fact-checking coup in 2008 when, after Hillary Clinton referred on the campaign trail to landing "under sniper fire" on a trip to Bosnia a decade earlier, the MRC found taped news video in its archive that showed the First Lady being greeted in a happy ceremony on an airport tarmac.[87] (As reviewed in chapter 4, mainstream fact-checkers picked up the story several days later—without crediting the conservative outlet that broke it.) The MRC enjoys a prominent profile across conservative media networks, with Bozell and other key figures frequently appearing on Fox News programs and similar outlets.

Fairness & Accuracy in Reporting

The group Fairness & Accuracy in Reporting (FAIR) appeared in 1986 as a "progressive" counterpart to Irvine's AIM. In an essay on FAIR's first birthday, founder Jeff Cohen, a former ACLU attorney, pointed to a rising rightward tilt in the "major media" due to corporate consolidation and to conservative media critics "harassing journalists who uncovered unpleasant truths

about poverty, inequality, government corruption or U.S. military and nuclear policy."[88] FAIR's mission emphasizes three related strands: documenting conservative or corporate bias in the news media, increasing the presence of progressive or "dissenting" voices, and advocating structural media reforms that favor this sort of diversity. FAIR criticizes the establishment press—and especially the *New York Times*—as relentlessly as conservative critics. One academic profile argues that FAIR has earned "a reputation as an authoritative press critic and media analyst among the MSM"; its studies of sources and guests on news programs have been credited with prompting editorial shifts at outlets like ABC's *Nightline* and PBS's *NewsHour*.[89] (After a 1990 study, for example, the PBS program began to feature prominent left figures such as Noam Chomsky and Edward Said.) The nonprofit has a staff of seven today and a relatively meager budget, just under $600,000 in 2013. It does not accept advertising or corporate funding and claims that 60 percent of revenue comes from contributions and subscriptions, with foundations providing the rest.

FAIR's activities mix research with activism and media production. The group puts out a monthly magazine, *Extra!*, and a weekly radio show, *CounterSpin*; it also prompts public phone and e-mail campaigns with "action alerts" to a mailing list of more than fifty-five thousand. FAIR's media critique often rests on close factual analysis to contest the phrasing or framing of news reports, sometimes citing nonpartisan fact-checkers. Its blog and radio program occasionally feature pieces billed directly as fact checks that take aim at journalists as sources of misinformation or misrepresentation. ("Well, let's factcheck Factcheck," FAIR announced in a reply to FactCheck .org's finding that Social Security was not created by Democrats.)[90] The group also frequently criticizes fact checks from established news outlets for false balance: "One of the problems with media 'factchecking' is the notion that all things must be 'checked' equally."[91]

Media Matters for America

The media watchdog whose work most closely resembles mainstream fact-checking is Media Matters for America. The group describes itself as "a progressive research and information center dedicated to comprehensively monitoring, analyzing, and correcting conservative misinformation."[92] It

was founded in 2004 by David Brock, a journalist best known for sensational exposés of the Clintons before publicly renouncing his conservative views in the late nineties. After his conversion, Brock became active on the left, and Media Matters enjoys close ties to Democratic funding networks. In 2010 the group had seventy employees and a budget of $10 million.[93] The organization regularly publishes research documenting conservative or corporate bias in the news, or analyzing coverage of issues such as climate change. It has also run high-profile campaigns against conservative media figures (most famously, a successful push for CBS to fire Don Imus after the radio host referred to a women's basketball team as "nappy-headed hoes").

Week to week, Media Matters operates as a kind of permanent political campaign, with staffers scanning broadcast, print, and online news outlets in three shifts spanning an eighteen-hour day.[94] This results in hundreds of articles each week calling attention to errors and distortions, especially on Fox News, which Media Matters clips avidly. The group focuses more directly on issues of fact than other media watchdogs and produces lengthy, meticulously documented analyses that often rely on the same sources employed by mainstream fact-checkers, whom it also regularly cites. (In a 2010 interview, Tate Williams, then chief of staff, described the organization's mission to me as "to stop a smear in its tracks," arguing that this involves doing the investigative work that reporters too often neglect.[95]) At the same time, though, reports on Media Matters slip into the sort of ideologically freighted language that nonpartisan journalists avoid. The site's debunking takes aim exclusively at conservative media figures and politicians, a point professional fact-checkers invariably make to show that Media Matters is not a trustworthy source.[96]

Drawing Boundaries in the Fact-Checking Universe

Journalists who produce fact checks in traditional newsrooms or at dedicated sites like PolitiFact and FactCheck.org do not view partisan media critics as legitimate peers. On the contrary, professional fact-checkers take pains to distinguish their own objective newswork from what they see as political argument making. They do not cite partisan outlets like Media Matters or the MRC in published articles, nor do they link to these sites in their snapshots of fact-checking around the web. (PolitiFact, FactCheck.org, and the Fact Checker all publicize the work of rival fact-checkers via their websites

or Twitter feeds. This sometimes includes nonjournalistic outlets, such as Snopes.com, but never partisan sites.) Professional fact-checkers go to great lengths to avoid being associated with counterparts in the political world, for instance, by avoiding joint appearances in panel discussions or news interviews. Fact-checkers can be quite frank about this aversion. At a 2011 meeting the *Washington Post*'s Glenn Kessler told other journalists, "I actually have a really sinking feeling if I start to fact-check something and I see, oh, God, Media Matters has already looked into this, and sometimes I'll just not even touch it 'cause it feels like it's already been tainted."[97]

Still, partisan media critics participate vocally in daily political discourse in the United States, and understanding their role helps to shed light on the work of professional fact-checkers. This is true, first of all, precisely because the latter disassociate themselves from their partisan counterparts so strenuously. The understanding and practice of fact-checking by professional journalists have been shaped, in part, by this kind of "boundary work."[98] The contrast with partisan sites gives mainstream outlets both another reason and another way to articulate their own vision of what legitimate fact-checking looks like. This professional line drawing takes place in public and in private—for example, in training sessions, new staff or interns are told very clearly who counts as a fact-checkers and who does not. As in classic examples of boundary work, professional rewards and resources are at stake here: status, autonomy, career advancement, and so on. However, in contrast to some other cases of boundary drawing noted by journalism scholars—between "serious" and tabloid reporters, for instance, or between traditional and "participatory" news—fact-checkers are not warding off a direct professional challenge from media watchdogs.[99] The outsiders in this case are truly that; partisan media critics have little prospect of and less desire for recognition in the journalistic establishment. Rather, in constantly affirming the divide between fact-checking and partisan critique, fact-checkers shore up the professional claims of their *own* new and sometimes controversial genre. The intended audience is other elite journalists.

For their part, media watchdog groups are among the most eager consumers and sharpest critics of journalistic fact-checking. They publicize rulings that support their own arguments and vehemently dispute those that don't. Media Matters has referred to the three national fact-checkers in thousands of posts, usually in order to cite their work as evidence of conservative

misinformation. But Media Matters also regularly accuses fact-checkers of "false balance" (and even ran an editorial cartoon directly mocking PolitiFact founder Bill Adair, pictured blithely defending a controversial Truth-O-Meter ruling about Medicare as Republicans dismantle the program).[100] The less prolific NewsBusters has made hundreds of references to the fact-checkers and includes PolitiFact on its list of "people and organizations" tracked. After PolitiFact greeted the news of U.S. House member Michele Bachmann's 2013 retirement with a review of her terrible Truth-O-Meter record, NewsBusters attacked the fact-checker's "extremely skewed methodology."[101] At the same time, the conservative site has reported with delight on the "years-long pissing contest" between PolitiFact and the liberal MSNBC host Rachel Maddow. When that dispute flared again in June 2014 (after PolitiFact challenged Maddow's recollection of the controversy over rescued prisoner of war Jessica Lynch a decade earlier), NewsBusters came to PolitiFact's defense with its own fact check of the liberal pundit.[102]

A Division of Critical Labor

Professional fact-checkers prefer to ignore the attention they receive, favorable or otherwise, from partisan media watchdogs. They almost never engage directly with these critics. In contrast, fact-checkers carefully tend their relationships with mainstream media outlets and often respond publicly to praise or censure from that quarter. After the 2012 presidential race, for example, both PolitiFact and FactCheck.org ran letters from their founders answering the charge, leveled by figures like the late *New York Times* media reporter David Carr, that fact-checking hadn't made a difference.[103] But sites like Media Matters and NewsBusters can't be ignored completely. They are busy nodes in online media-political networks, covering the same ground as the fact-checkers day after day. They turn up in broadcast transcripts and op-ed pages and search results, influencing the fact-checkers if only by the "taint" they attach to certain issues or arguments. Like other journalists today, fact-checkers read their professional status in the media footprint of their own work. Their standing as legitimate, objective voices is reflected in and reproduced by the shifting pattern of media-political actors who cite and quote and link to them. Partisan media critics are an unavoidable feature of that network landscape.

Looking broadly at a fact-checking universe that includes journalists as well as media watchdogs and other political voices highlights the way the new genre bridges adjacent professional domains. Almost any deceptive claim that gains traction in public discourse can be debunked in two distinct modes: as uttered by a misleading politician or as reproduced by irresponsible journalists. Perhaps the best-known episode in the history and lore of fact-checking is the controversy over "death panels" sparked by a 2009 Facebook post from vice presidential candidate Sarah Palin. Claims that President Obama's health care reform plan envisioned some kind of euthanasia for unproductive members of society met a wide array of fact-checking responses. FactCheck.org and PolitiFact challenged Palin's claim directly; Media Matters fact-checked the "Fox News personalities" who promoted it; and FAIR faulted *USA Today* and other mainstream news outlets for failing to debunk the claim and thus helping to legitimize outlandish rhetoric.[104] The fact checks by professional journalists noted in passing how rhetoric about death panels had caught fire in the news media, but they did not fault their peers for fanning the flames.

This consistent pattern underscores a fairly simple division of critical labor between the fields that overlap in fact-checking: media actors focus their critique on politics while political actors direct theirs at the media. Journalists by instinct and by charter tend to attribute faults in the public sphere to the behavior of politicians or to the nature of politics, episodes of professional self-flagellation notwithstanding. Fact-checkers share the occupational cynicism of political reporters generally; they are quick to argue that lying is a basic feature of politics and that no amount of fact-checking will change that. Meanwhile, political actors—including campaigns, party organizations, issue groups, and activists—see the news media as a primary arena of political contestation. Political campaigns measure their own progress, justifiably or not, through day-to-day media coverage.[105] Perhaps as a result, the institutional logic of politics tends to blame adverse outcomes on inadequate or unfair coverage and, often, to see reforming the media as the most hopeful route to political change.

The fact-checking organizations this book focuses on are led and staffed by reporters with long backgrounds in print and broadcast news. They place themselves squarely in the tradition of objective journalism and subscribe

to norms that wall reporting off from the political realm. They see themselves as journalists and not media critics. Still, I will argue throughout that fact-checking represents a serious and sustained critique of conventional political reporting. Fact-checkers organize and understand their work around this shared critique, one with a long history in and out of journalism that they have carried into practice in a new way online. This is why it makes sense to understand fact-checking as a kind of professional reform movement—as an argument about how objectivity *should* be practiced, a point developed in the next chapter. Michael Schudson's description of an earlier generation of upstart reporters (who led the resurgence of investigative journalism in the sixties and seventies) applies equally well to the new fact-checkers: "They make a case for a journalism true to an ideal of objectivity and false to the counterfeit conventions justified in its name."[106]

This chapter has surveyed the landscape of fact-checking in order to understand how this professional movement fits into the journalistic field and into the wider sphere of elite political communication. Fact-checkers represent a distinct cohort at the center of political journalism—one with recognized leaders, with its own emergent subset of journalistic norms and practices, and with an increasingly stable vocabulary to address recurring internal debates and points of tension. I've argued that fact-checking appeals to the profession's core democratic values while also reflecting particular sources of outside influence. First, as a subfield of U.S. journalism, fact-checking has unusually close ties to the nonprofit and academic worlds. Fact-checkers have grown increasingly comfortable speaking the language of these neighboring fields and seeking funding and legitimacy through them—although, as we shall see, these links are also sources of tension in defining the mission and practice of fact-checking. And second, the practices and discourse of professional fact-checking reflect these journalists' constant efforts to distinguish themselves from partisan counterparts. As both competitors to and critics of professional fact-checkers, partisan media critics are an unavoidable feature of online political discourse. Boundary drawing helps fact-checkers to articulate and define correct practice and to reinforce their own claim to journalistic legitimacy. All of these influential outsiders—political actors, media critics, and academics—figure prominently in the cases and episodes developed in the following chapters.